

EAM310 EAST ASIAN MEDICINE DIAGNOSIS I · VUIM SUMMER 2026

Week 3: Pulse Diagnosis

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Friday, July 25, 2026 · 9:00 AM – 1:00 PM · Prof. Daniel Schrier D.O.M. L.Ac.

⚠️ QUIZ 2 — Thursday July 24 · Eight Principles & Zang-Fu Basics | QUIZ 3 — July 31 · Pulse Diagnosis (next week)

REQUIRED READINGS

FCM Ch. 8 — Pulse Diagnosis	pp. 129–160
FCM Ch. 7 — Tongue Diagnosis	pp. 107–128
CAM Ch. 4 — Four Methods	pp. 127–145
MOA — Pulse sections	ref.
Handbook of Contemp. Pulse Dx	supplement

ASSESSMENT CALENDAR

Quiz	Date	Topic
Q1	Jul 17 ✓	Vital Substances
Q2	Jul 24	Eight Principles
Q3	Jul 31	Pulse Dx
MID + J1–25	Aug 7	Comprehensive
Q4–Q6	Aug 21–Sep 4	TBD
FINAL + J26–50	Sep 11	Comprehensive

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

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Locate 6 pulse positions & organ assignments

▶ Describe 胃神根 (Wei/Shen/Gen) of normal pulse

▶ Identify 29 pulse qualities with clinical significance

▶ Execute 6-step palpation sequence

▶ Correlate seasonal pulses & Six Climatic Qi

▶ Apply pulse findings to Shang Han Lun stages

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1. Position patient's wrist — palm up, slight dorsiflexion, pillow support

▶ 2. Place index finger at Cun (腕横纹 wrist crease)

▶ 3. Place middle finger at Guan (桡骨茎突 styloid process)

▶ 4. Place ring finger at Chi (尺部)

▶ 5. Apply 3 levels of pressure (浮·中·沉)

▶ 6. Count rate for ≥1 full minute; assess 9 parameters

SIX PULSE POSITIONS — 六部脉 (LIÙ BÙ MÀI)

Position	漢字	Left Hand (左)	Right Hand (右)
Cun 寸 (distal)	寸	Heart (HT) / Pericardium	Lung (LU)
Guan 关 (middle)	关	Liver (LV) / Gallbladder	Spleen (SP) / Stomach
Chi 尺 (proximal)	尺	Kidney Yin (KD-Yin)	Kidney Yang (KD-Yang)

Note: Some traditions assign GB at Left Guan superficial and LV at Left Guan deep; ST at Right Guan superficial and SP at Right Guan deep. Verify with Prof. Schrier's position.

NORMAL PULSE — 胃神根 (WÈI SHÉN GĒN)

Quality	漢字 / Pinyin	Meaning	Clinical Significance
Stomach Qi	胃 Wèi	Soft, slightly slippery quality with gentle wave at middle level	Reflects abundance of Stomach/Spleen Qi; absent = critical prognosis
Spirit	神 Shén	Forceful yet yielding; has "life" or rhythmic vitality	Reflects strength of Heart Qi & overall vitality
Root	根 Gēn	Felt at deep (Chi) level; strong at proximal positions	Reflects Kidney Qi & constitutional essence; absent = poor prognosis

NORMAL PULSE PARAMETERS

Parameter	Normal Finding	Notes
Rate	60–90 BPM (4–5 beats / practitioner breath)	Children faster; elderly slightly slower
Rhythm	Regular — evenly spaced beats	Occasional missed beat in otherwise healthy: may be normal
Depth	Felt equally at floating & deep; strongest at middle	Varies by body type & season
Strength	Moderate force; neither empty nor full	Reflects Qi & Blood adequacy
Shape/Width	Moderate — not too wide, not too thin	Wide = Excess; thin/minute = Deficiency
Length	Fills all 3 positions (Cun → Chi)	Long = Excess; Short = Deficiency of Qi
Tension	Moderately taut — not wiry, not flaccid	Wiry = Liver/GB pattern; Tight = Cold
Smoothness	Smooth flow; moderate slipperiness	Choppy = Blood Xu or Stasis

FACTORS AFFECTING THE PULSE

Physiological Age · Sex · Body type · Pregnancy · Exercise just prior · Emotional state · Season & time of day	Pathological Excess → full, rapid, wiry Deficiency → empty, thin, weak Cold → slow, tight, sinking Heat → rapid, full, flooding	Constitutional "Diagonal Pulse" (斜飞脉) — radial artery courses differently Inverted Pulse — felt on dorsal wrist; not pathological
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GROUP 1: DEPTH 深度 (SHĒN DÙ)

Floating 浮 Fú

Exterior Cold/Wind Xu

Feel: Felt at superficial level; diminishes with pressure. Like wood floating on water.
Clinical: Exterior patterns (early-stage pathogen); also Yin Xu with floating Yang

Sinking 沉 Chén

Interior Cold Xu/Shi

Feel: Only felt at deep level; must press firmly. Like a stone sinking.
Clinical: Interior patterns; Cold/Deficiency if weak; Interior Excess if forceful

Scattered 散 Sǎn

Severe Xu Yin Xu

Feel: Floating but irregular; no root; disperses under pressure. Like scattered leaves.
Clinical: Collapse of Kidney Qi; critical/terminal condition; late-stage disease

Hidden 伏 Fú

Severe Cold Extreme Shi

Feel: Deeper than sinking; only felt pressing to bone. Like hidden treasure.
Clinical: Extreme Cold retention; severe pain; syncope; Yang collapse

GROUP 2: RATE 频率 (PÍN Lǜ)

Slow 迟 Chí

Cold Yang Xu

Rate: <60 BPM (fewer than 4 beats/breath)
Clinical: Cold patterns (Excess Cold or Yang Xu); also seen in athletes (physiological)

Rapid 数 Shuò

Heat Yin Xu

Rate: >90 BPM (more than 5 beats/breath)
Clinical: Heat patterns; also Yin Xu (rapid, fine, floating); fever

Knotted 结 Jié

Cold Blood Stasis Phlegm

Feel: Slow rate with irregular missed beats; pauses at irregular intervals
Clinical: Cold obstructing Qi; Blood Stasis; Phlegm accumulation

Hurried / Racing 促 Cù

Heat Blood Stasis

Feel: Rapid rate with irregular missed beats; pauses at irregular intervals
Clinical: Heat obstructing Qi; extreme excess; imminent collapse

GROUP 3: STRENGTH 力度 (LÌ DÙ)

Full / Excess 实 Shí

Excess Heat

Feel: Forceful at all 3 levels; large, strong wave; doesn't yield to pressure
Clinical: Excess patterns; vigorous pathogenic factor; strong constitution

Empty / Deficient 虚 Xū

Deficiency Qi Xu

Feel: Soft, lacking force at all 3 levels; wide but without strength
Clinical: Qi and Blood Deficiency; overall deficiency patterns

GROUP 4: SHAPE / TENSION 形态 (XÍNG TÀI)

Wiry 弦 Xián

Liver/GBPainPhlegm

Feel: Taut, like a plucked string of a musical instrument; straight, hard

Clinical: Liver Qi Stagnation; Liver & GB disease; pain; Phlegm accumulation; hypertension. Also seasonal in Spring.

Slippery 滑 Huá

PhlegmDampPregnancy

Feel: Smooth, flowing easily under finger; like pearls rolling on a plate

Clinical: Phlegm; Dampness; food retention; Heat; pregnancy (normal in fertile women)

Tight 紧 Jǐn

ColdPain

Feel: Taut and twisting like a twisted rope; harder than wiry; has rotation quality

Clinical: Cold (Interior & Exterior); pain; food stagnation

Choppy 涩 Sè

Blood XuBlood StasisFluid Xu

Feel: Rough, uneven, hesitant; like a knife scraping bamboo; short & slow

Clinical: Blood Deficiency; Blood Stasis; Body Fluid Deficiency; Seven Emotions

WIRY VS. TIGHT — KEY DISTINCTION

Feature	Wiry 弦 Xián	Tight 紧 Jǐn
Sensation	Taut, straight — like a bowstring or wire	Taut AND twisting — like a twisted rope
Primary etiology	Liver Qi Stagnation / Liver-GB disease	Cold invasion / Interior Cold
Secondary	Pain, Phlegm, hypertension, Spring season	Pain, food stagnation
Mnemonic	"Guitar string" — straight tension	"Wet towel wrung" — twisted, harder

SLIPPERY VS. CHOPPY — KEY DISTINCTION

Feature	Slippery 滑 Huá	Choppy 涩 Sè
Sensation	Smooth, rolling, flowing easily	Rough, hesitant, uneven, slow
Substance excess/deficient	Excess (Phlegm, Damp, fluid accumulation)	Deficiency (Blood Xu, Body Fluid Xu)
Can also indicate	Pregnancy (normal); Heat	Blood Stasis (excess but obstructed)

GROUP 4B: ADDITIONAL SHAPE QUALITIES

Leather 革 Gé

Xu ColdBlood Xu

Feel: Floating, hollow, drum-like; firm on outside, empty inside. Like a leather drum.

Clinical: Jing/Essence Deficiency; Blood loss; miscarriage; nocturnal emission

Firm 牢 Láo

Interior ColdExcess

Feel: Deep, wiry, large, long, strong; only felt at deep level

Clinical: Interior Cold accumulation; masses/growths; Yin excess

GROUP 5: LENGTH 长度 (CHÁNG DÙ)

Long 长 Cháng

Excess Heat/Yang

Feel: Extends beyond Cun & Chi positions; felt beyond the 3 positions
Clinical: Excess patterns; Liver Yang Rising; Heat; also can be normal in tall people or robust constitution

Short 短 Duǎn

Qi Xu

Feel: Does not fill all 3 positions; mainly felt at Guan (middle), absent at Cun & Chi
Clinical: Qi Deficiency; also Qi stagnation (excess type)

GROUP 6: WIDTH 宽度 (KUĀN DÙ)

Big / Surging / Flooding 洪 Hóng

Heat Excess

Feel: Surges powerfully under finger; comes strong, leaves weak; like ocean waves
Clinical: Excess Heat; Yang Ming stage; high fever; normal in Summer

Minute / Faint 微 Wēi

Severe Xu Yang Xu

Feel: Extremely thin and weak; almost imperceptible; barely felt even at deep level
Clinical: Severe Yang Deficiency; Qi & Blood collapse; critical condition

Soggy / Soft 濡 Rú

Qi/Blood Xu Damp

Feel: Floating, thin, soft; disappears with pressure; like floating cotton
Clinical: Qi & Blood Deficiency; Dampness (thin but floating)

Weak 弱 Ruò

Qi/Blood Xu Yang Xu

Feel: Deep, thin, soft; only felt at deep level; disappears with pressure
Clinical: Qi & Blood Deficiency; Yang Xu; long-term chronic disease

GROUP 7: RHYTHM 节律 (JIÉ Lǜ)

Intermittent / Regularly Irregular 代 Dài

Organ Xu Severe

Feel: Slow with regular missed beats at fixed intervals; long pause after skipped beat
Clinical: Organ Qi Deficiency (heart, spleen); severe internal disease; also normal during pregnancy or fright

Moving 动 Dòng

Pain Fright

Feel: Short, slippery, and rapid; found at Guan position only; shape like a bean
Clinical: Severe pain; extreme fright; Jing Deficiency with Heat

Racing / Stirred 疾 Jí

Extreme Heat Yang Xu

Rate: >120 BPM (7+ beats/breath); extremely rapid
Clinical: Extreme Yang Excess with Yin collapse; terminal Yang floating

SEASONAL NORMAL PULSES — 四季脉

Season	Dates (approx.)	Normal Pulse	汉字	Physiology
Spring 春	Mar 21 – Jun 20	Wiry 弦 Xián	弦	Liver Qi rises; Wood element activates; Yang begins to emerge
Summer 夏	Jun 21 – Sep 22	Flooding / Surging 洪 Hóng	洪	Heart rules; Yang at peak; Qi and Blood move rapidly to surface
Late Summer 长夏	Jul 21 – Aug 20	Moderate / Slippery 缓 Huǎn · 滑 Huá	缓/滑	Spleen/Stomach rule; Earth element; Dampness present; digestive Qi strongest
Autumn 秋	Sep 23 – Dec 20	Floating / Hair 毛 Máo (superficial)	毛/浮	Lung rules; Metal element; Yang recedes inward; Wei Qi consolidates
Winter 冬	Dec 21 – Mar 20	Sinking / Stone 石 Shí (deep)	石/沉	Kidney rules; Water element; Yang retreats inward to conserve; Yin dominates

Key principle: Seasonal pulse variations are NORMAL — do not pathologize. A floating pulse in Autumn is expected; the same pulse in Winter may indicate Exterior invasion.

SIX CLIMATIC QI — 六气 (LIÙ QÌ) PULSE ASSOCIATIONS

Climatic Factor 六气	Pīnyīn	Season	Pulse Tendency	Symptoms to Correlate
Wind 风	Fēng	Spring	Floating, wiry; may be irregular	Aversion to wind, headache, stiff neck, migratory pain
Cold 寒	Hán	Winter	Tight, slow, sinking	Chills, pain, contraction, aversion to cold
Summerheat 暑	Shǔ	Summer	Rapid, flooding, soft	High fever, profuse sweating, thirst, fatigue
Dampness 湿	Shī	Late Summer	Soggy, slippery, moderate	Heaviness, turbid secretions, poor digestion
Dryness 燥	Zào	Autumn	Choppy, thin, slightly floating	Dry mouth/throat, dry skin, constipation
Fire / Heat 火	Huǒ	All seasons	Rapid, full, surging	High fever, red face, thirst for cold, agitation

SHANG HAN LUN — SIX STAGE PULSE GUIDE 伤寒论六经脉证

Stage 经	Organs	Characteristic Pulse	Key Symptoms
Tai Yang 太阳	BL / SI	Floating (浮 Fú)	Chills, fever, stiff neck, aversion to cold/wind
Yang Ming 阳明	ST / LI	Surging/Full (洪大 Hóng Dà)	High fever, profuse sweat, constipation, 4 bigs
Shao Yang 少阳	GB / TH	Wiry (弦 Xián)	Alternating chills & fever, hypochondrial pain, bitter taste
Tai Yin 太阴	SP / LU	Moderate/Slow (缓迟 Huǎn Chí)	Abdominal fullness/pain, diarrhea, vomiting, cold limbs
Shao Yin 少阴	HT / KD	Minute/Thin (微细 Wēi Xì)	Extreme cold, sleepiness, cold extremities, weak voice
Jue Yin 厥阴	LV / PC	Wiry, rapid (弦数 Xián Shuò)	Alternating heat/cold, Jue (reversal) of extremities, thirst

PATTERN INSERT — EAM310 · Week 3 · Pulse Diagnosis

PATTERN NAME	TCM DX CATEGORY	EIGHT PRINCIPLES
ETIOLOGY / PATHOMECHANISM	ZANG-FU INVOLVED	
CHIEF COMPLAINT / KEY SYMPTOMS	SEASONAL / CLIMATIC FACTOR	

TONGUE & PULSE FINDINGS

CHINESE MEDICINE
TONGUE MAP

	Left 左	Right 右
寸 Cun HT / LU		
关 Guan LV / SP		
尺 Chi KD-Yin / KD-Yang		

Overall quality: _____ Rate: _____ Rhythm: _____

TREATMENT PRINCIPLE & KEY POINTS / HERBS

TREATMENT PRINCIPLE	KEY ACUPOINTS

KEY HERBS / FORMULA
